

ROLEPLAYING IN THE WORLD OF COYOTE & CROW

What Is The World Of Coyote & Crow?

Coyote & Crow is a world very different from our own, despite being set on Earth and not that far in the future. Yet it is a different future based on a divergent past. Both worlds share the exact same history up to a certain key moment. That event, that single difference, changed everything, reshaping this world away from our own and into the world you see in this book.

In our world, the monarchies of Europe pushed westward through the 15th century, determined to find faster routes to India, China, and other valuable trading partners. Instead they crashed headlong into something far more valu-

able – land and resources that they could exploit. Along the way they devastated entire Native populations through murder, slavery, exploitation, and the spread of disease. But what if that hadn't happened? In the world of Coyote & Crow, things took a different turn. This world's history went down another path and the resulting changes created a landscape that bears little resemblance to our own.

What was this change? People call it The Awis - the Darkest Night or The Darkening Land.

Around the year we think of as 1400 AD, something monumental happened. In years past it was often said a great evil, a darkness, one so powerful that it forced the Great Spirit to flee, had covered the world. Later it came to be un-

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derstood that something had struck the world, likely a massive meteor, bringing both radiation and rare elements as well as exotic matter previously unknown to our planet. The explanation held true whether one preferred the poetic or scientific description.

The result was that the Earth was plunged into a severe climate change for hundreds of years. How it affected the rest of the world, no one knows for sure. But the people of what we call North and South America were not let off easily. They faced a growing northern ice shelf, extended winters, violent oceans, huge changes in animal and plant populations, starvation, and war. Tribes moved, changed, and evolved. They adapted to the world they inherited and used the gifts left to them by the Great Spirit. Though the Awis plunged the world into a deep ice age, it also brought a strange mark on plants, animals, and people; the purple mark called the Adanadi, a source of inspiration first, and later, power. Eventually, the weather improved. The seas calmed, the ice shelf slowly began to melt and retreat northward. New technologies and trade brought a huge upswing in the standard of living for all.

The Characters you will play in this game are the inheritors of all these changes. These are people who live in a very different world from ours and yet, where it counts, they are just like us. They love and fight, have families and dreams. Nations go to war and make treaties. Engineers and scientists make discoveries that improve and complicate daily living. People strive to make sense of their lives, bring meaning to their efforts, and understand the world around them.

This is also a world where legend meets science. In our world, this is often seen as a battle between right and wrong or good and evil. It is the idea that one has to be fundamentally correct and by necessity, the other wrong. This viewpoint comes primarily from a western European way of thinking. In Coyote & Crow, an advanced piece of science can still have spiritual value. A supernatural experience doesn't have to be dismissed because science doesn't easily explain it. For most folks, the mystical and the logical exist side by side on a daily basis.

Many things in this game are rooted in our shared history. The city of Cahokia, for example, is a

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real place and worth reading about. Where appropriate, real world names have been kept for certain things. The non-English words in this game are either based on real world Indigenous languages or were crafted from real languages as part of a fictional language we have developed for this game called Chahi.

On the other hand, many things we take for granted in our world have no basis in Coyote & Crow. For example, the people of this world decided at some point to unify and share an annual calendar; they picked the night of The Awis as its starting point. It was, after all, one of the few things that all of these tribes and nations had a very specific shared memory of. In this game when someone refers to the year 693, they're referring to 693 years after The Awis. They have no concept of Christian calendars.

It's also vital to understand that without contact from Europeans, certain things we take for granted in our modern world don't currently exist. There were never cars in this world because there were never wagons. There aren't combustion engines, gunpowder, or traditional firearms. There's no fry

bread, no cows, chickens, pigs, coffee, and so much more. Instead, the people of Coyote & Crow developed their societies and technologies as they had for thousands of years prior – through necessity, creativity, cleverness, and North and South America's rich abundance of resources.

Some other things that don't exist in this world: Alcoholic drinks (alcohol exists, but not as a part of the culture in any relevant format), fossil fuels, culturally embedded shame over nudity and sexuality, wheat and wheat products, industrial meat farming. The list is long.

Because of just how different this world might be, often in unexpected ways, we're going to sometimes call out comparisons to our real world to help you understand how this one is different. We hope it helps you to picture and embrace this vibrant world. From here out, we're going to leave our real world behind and dive into a new one. This book will focus mostly on Makasing (North America) and the people that live there. More specifically, we will be detailing the city of Cahokia and the area surrounding it known as the Free Lands. Future books will de-

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tail the other nations of North America and the people in Central and South America (Azayang and Abayang).

The World That Could Be

700 years ago, a purple streak crossed the night sky. Many tribes of the time said that it was the Great Spirit leaving them behind, abandoning the world to its fate. In the days following, the skies filled with dark clouds, the air choked with ash, the seas frothed and raged. Once the snows fell that winter, they fell long and hard. Harder than any could re-

member. Over the next few years, winter grew in strength, dominating the seasonal cycle.

Food became scarce. As people starved, hostilities flared and wars broke out. Throughout the land, the tribes struggled against the Earth and against each other. The ice caps crept down from the north, growing thicker and stronger, pushing people together, forcing them to share land and resources. Every tribe had to face the hard truth of possible extinction. Some met that very fate.



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But people also endured. They managed survival, at first. Slowly, they adapted and eventually they didn't just survive, they thrived. In the East, great leaders began to shape concepts of fair government. In the West and North, brilliant artists and storytellers captivated audiences and gave hope to the desperate. In the Southeast, there were incredible advances in medicine and biology. In the Southwest, breakthroughs in mathematics and farming changed everything on the continent. Combined with trade and other technology coming from the central and southern continents, life across the land began to transform from barely livable to a triumphant return from the brink.

No one can deny that things really changed with the realization of the Adanadi – the Gift. It started hundreds of years back. No one is exactly sure when or where, although the earliest scientific evidence suggests the first instances of The Gift were seen more than 500 years ago, just a couple of hundred years after the Awis. People began to notice purple stains or marks on certain plants, animals, and people. Many people of the time took it as a sign that the Great Spirit might be gone, but that She'd left them a tool, a gift, something to help them get

through the Darkest Night and the horrors it brought. For generations, it was carefully cultivated and bred, treated as sacred. It wasn't until advances in the understanding of biology and chemistry that tribes were able to unlock the true potential of the Adanadi and verify that it is, in itself, a form of life, something beyond known biology that remains within the body of the individual.

Introducing more of the Adanadi into the body at just the right point in adolescence transforms the person permanently, improving them physiologically and sometimes granting them abilities beyond normal human parameters. The choice to take a specific form of the Adanadi, concentrated from a specific animal, became known as choosing your Path. While different nations and tribes have an array of ceremonies and customs surrounding this ritual, they all have many common aspects.

Once chosen and consumed, the person is generally considered an adult and is permanently on that Path. Paths are most commonly named after animals, since taking Adanadi from a specific animal allows the Gift to carry genetic information from the previous host to the individual, making the two now literally relatives. This is both

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spiritual in nature and scientifically based. While most people have consumed the Adanadi and then gone about their daily lives, some people step into a larger circle, a place where heroes are born and stories that last for generations are created. You'll be playing these characters. People who are destined to become parts of legends told around future fires.

In the last forty years, the damage done by the Awis finally seems to be healing. Winters are shortening, summers are growing longer. The ice cap is retreating and the seas are calming. Within the governments, curiosity about the outside world beyond their current geographical borders is starting to outweigh the political strength of those that cling to fears of the past. While it has been known for hundreds of years that there were other continents and maybe even other people across the world, the weather and internal political strife has kept people close to home.

Now though, with the climate evening out and with nations possessing rapidly advancing technology and the will to use it, the race is on to explore this great new world; to discover new resources and power, to make discoveries for scientific progress, and to meet

new people for crafting strategic alliances.

But things haven't gone according to plan. Ships sent to sea in search of distant lands rarely return. Expeditions north through the snow and ice are often lost for good. The few that returned have come back mostly empty handed. Rumors swirl about what they've found, what they experienced, and what awaits people across the waters. While many people were prepared to discount the legends of monsters and spirits, they became harder to dismiss when people living along the outskirts of well-traveled land began reporting some of the same strange phenomena.

Many now believe that while the change in weather has allowed people to venture out, it might also be opening the door to let things in. And the dangers in this world aren't just external. With a surge in population and an explosion in new technology, old treaties created when the climate was suffering are no longer enough to keep some nations and leaders from looking to expand their advantages over their neighbors. Many nations were created during times of war out of necessity. The tribes and factions of this world have very little value

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for nationalism. Leaders of these nations often find themselves struggling to simply keep their governments from falling apart from the inside. Civil war or secession is often just as much a threat as international conflict. Fears of espionage run rampant, especially with spies now possessing access to Adanadi-gifted Abilities.

Regardless of how comfortable and steady life might be for many people now, no one is unaware that true change lies on the horizon. The era of the Darkest Night is coming to an end. Yet many of

the obstacles previous generations overcame don't change the fact that new challenges and mysteries lie just ahead. This is the world your Characters will step into and the backdrop for their future legends.

Below is a map and a brief timeline of historical events on the continent of Makasing in this alternate future that will help you understand some of the more important milestones and turning points for this world.



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Coyote & Crow's Timeline

Year 1: In our world the year was 1402. The Awis arrives (sometimes called The Darkened Land or Darkest Night). A purple streak passes through the sky, high enough that most tribes have records or stories of seeing it. Weeks later, a strange ash falls and winter comes early.

Year 2-115: Winters are longer and harder than any ever remember. The ice sheet over the north half of the northern continent grows thicker and spreads south. People in the northern part of Makasing are forced southward ahead of the ice. The lack of food and other resources pushes groups into conflict. The loss of life is enormous.

Year 115-140: A respite in the weather allows people to rebound slightly. A few decent seasons of production allow population numbers to rise. The Haudenosaunee alliance is born in its modern form on the east coast. The city of Cahokia is reborn along the Mizizibi river, what we call the Mississippi.

Year 141-168: Harsh weather returns. Tribes all over the continent work together to improve food supplies, cooperation, and sustainability, but to limited success. Strictly organized farming becomes vital to keeping people alive.

Year 169: A Two-Spirit leader rises to power in the Southwest after visions lead them to create the base-twelve math system that eventually becomes the foundation for all higher math and engineering in Makasing. The resulting advances lead to a massive leap in irrigation and large scale farming.

Year 170-280: A new era of farming, medicine, and associated technology transforms the continent. Infighting drops, as do mortality rates. Math begins to be taught as something sacred and an engineering golden age begins.

Year 280-296: The purple stain, called the Adanadi, begins to appear on animals, plants, and people. It is considered a good omen. Herbalists and farmers begin to cultivate and breed plants and animals specifically for the mark.

Year 297-365: The Haudenosaunee nation surges in power. Tribes along the east coast become influential and form a massive nation state. While not unduly hostile, they project influence and strength in a way that many other tribes find threatening. Alliances and treaties continue to be signed, social and cultural lines between tribes continue to morph, and five geographic areas begin to form in the continent that will eventually make up the Five Na-

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tions of North America: Southwest, Northwest, Southeast, Northeast and Central. The Central area of the continent doesn't form into a single nation, but instead a loose organization of city-states, dominated by Cahokia, which is rapidly becoming the focal point for scholarly, spiritual, and political discourse across the continent, as well as a transcontinental trade hub.

Year 366-420: Through careful cultivation, breeding, and experimentation, scholars and medicine practitioners figure out how to create a reaction in humans once they've consumed a concentrated amount of the Adanadi from an animal. The subject gains heightened natural abilities, and sometimes something more; an ability beyond what is normal for humans. It quickly gains significance among tribes as a powerful ritual. Since the effect only happens the first time it is consumed in high levels, the animal is chosen carefully and must be consumed at the height of the recipient's adolescence.

Year 421-503: There is huge technological, political, social, and cultural growth, as the Adanadi allows for rapid change. Small wars erupt mostly over evolving concepts of farming rights and control over major freshwater sources. The first models of 3D printers appear,

called gats. The rise in education and the drop in mortality begin to cause social upheavals and the questioning of traditions. Math and science become increasingly important to the fabric of everyday life.

Year 504-518: A multiyear break in the harsh weather causes all the nation states of Makasing to assemble in Cahokia and discuss exploration of the outside world beyond the known continents. Safe sea travel had not been possible previously and the ice sheet to the North was in almost constant blizzard conditions. The tribes decide that the time is right to send explorers out to see what the rest of the world holds.

Year 518-550: Many groups of explorers leave. Few return. Those that do, tell a mix of stories about desolate wastelands, strange creatures that seem right out of legends, and powerful beings who wield the Adanadi with incredible might. Those reports either fall into rumor or are kept quiet by governments.

Year 550-612: Harsh weather returns, preventing governments from sending out fresh groups of explorers. There are religious uprisings throughout many nations. Those involved believe that the return of the explorers and the change back to harsh weather is a

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sign that the Great Spirit hasn't yet come back, and that going out beyond their current borders is inviting evil and chaos.

Year 612-623: The All Tribes War erupts. Initially a dispute between the Ezcan Empire and the Diné Republic, things escalate and both continents are pulled in. It's a war that economically cripples the vast majority of the nations in both Makasing, Azayang, and Abayang (North, Central, and South America). Cahokia escapes relatively unharmed and generally becomes recognized as one of the most important cities in the world.

Year 624-697: Decades pass with relative peace, prosperity, and technological growth. Many nations still trade and do business with each other, but after the

wars, there is a growing sense of cultural isolationism, nationalism, and tribalism.

Year 698-709: The weather breaks in a way it hasn't before. The climate settles and returns to pre-Awis levels. The seas calm, allowing for safer sea travel, especially with new advanced technology. There is an explosion of food, resources, and technology unlike anything anyone has ever seen.

Year 710: Now. Nations are looking to see how they can gain new advantages over their neighbors, to prosper further, to develop their lives, protect and nurture the world around them, and maybe even try again to explore beyond their continental borders. The future is uncertain and full of challenges.



MAKASING AND THE WORLD BEYOND

This Chapter details the places and people of Coyote & Crow. It describes the cities, nations, and continents and the cultures, technologies and notable places within each. To start, we're going to focus on the city of Cahokia. Then we will zoom out and talk about the Free Lands, the other nations on the continent of Makasing, and briefly look into the nations in the areas known as Abayang and Azayang.

Cahokia: An Introduction

Why Cahokia?

The world that you are entering is a big one. Trying to detail even five nations in this book would be a monumental task. That is just Makasing, not to mention the other seven nations. Just covering all the Free Lands is still an enormous task. Instead, we suggest you start your game in the city of Cahokia. Focusing on a single

metropolitan city will give you a chance to steep yourself in this world while also giving us the space to tell you about this amazing place in greater detail. Below is a description of daily life in Cahokia and what the city feels like. Additional details about telling stories in the city will be detailed in the chapter Forging Your Saga.

The Basics

Cahokia is the largest city in Makasing. It is home to over two million people and is widely considered the most diverse and culturally expansive city in the world. As a sovereign city-state, it bows to no one and has powerful treaties and alliances with every other nation in the world. It does not rule over the Free Lands, but it leads the other cities and municipalities through strong relationships and a shared understanding.

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The other city-states and governments within the Free Lands are autonomous and bound loosely through alliances with their immediate neighbors and Cahokia. Cahokia itself sits on more than 500 square miles of land along the Mizizibi river, roughly where the real-world city of St. Louis exists, and extends south.

The city has a long and fascinating history. Structures date back more than a 1000 years. The city was mostly abandoned prior to the Awis, but was revitalized years later as trade became more essential than ever. Eventually, the city became the birthplace of modern exchange, the root of a common trade language called Chahi, the most spoken language on the continent, and the originator of the most recognized currency in use, nizi.

Cahokia is a sprawling, energetic city, but not a hurried or crowded one. Between the large underground tunnel system, plenty of available land, and the warming weather, there is space for everyone. During the day, people work, play, learn, and farm. At night, there's a growing entertainment and leisure scene as people begin to truly reap the rewards of their hard work and advances.

Without the poverty and inequality present in our real world cities, there is not as much petty crime. But that doesn't mean that Cahokia is a safe place or that there aren't dangers. Clashing belief systems, political and spiritual, are always simmering below the surface. There are secrets around every corner and new threats lurking in every shadow.

